



Talking TERMS

Manmohan and Gilani agree on a new template to bring relations back on keel

| By Saurabh Shukla |

When Manmohan Singh took over as the prime minister in 2004, he was keen on taking India's relations with Pakistan to a new level of friendship and trust. While he did make some progress, it came to naught following the 26/11 Mumbai attacks and brought the dialogue process with Pakistan to a standstill. A new chill had set in.

So in 2009, in his second term, the prime minister pressed for a fresh beginning with Pakistan. On the side-

lines of the NAM Summit at the Egyptian town of Sharm El Sheikh he decided to have a long one-on-one talk with Pakistan Prime Minister Yousuf Raza Gilani on July 16. During the more than two-hour-long meeting, Manmohan indulged in frank talk, telling Pakistan that it needs to take visible measures on the issue of terrorism. India also suggested that Pakistan needs to take action similar to what it took against terror groups in its Swat region.

After several rounds of hard bargaining, the two issued a joint statement that said: "The dialogue is the

only way forward." They agreed that terrorism posed the major threat to both countries. Gilani assured Manmohan that Pakistan will do everything possible to bring the perpetrators of the Mumbai attacks to justice. While India got Pakistan to agree that terrorism was the central focus, it agreed that the composite dialogue should not be linked to terrorism. India conceded Pakistan's demand to mention Baluchistan in the joint statement while Pakistan also agreed to drop the mention of Kashmir. They also agreed to share real-time and actionable intelligence